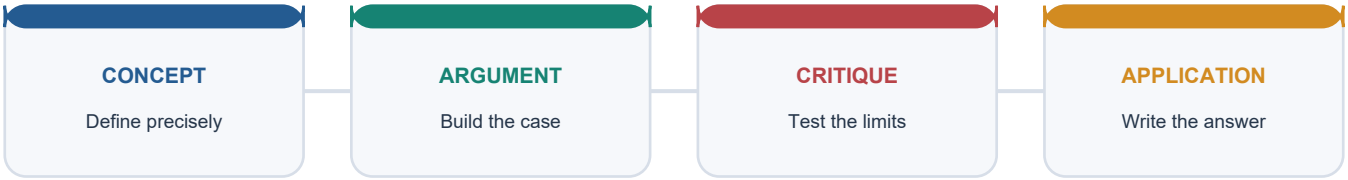
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Economic Impact of British Rule - Solved Practice Workbook

GS-I Modern Indian History | 32 solved MCQs, PYQs and Mains models

LEARNING PATH



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Economic Impact of British Rule - Solved Practice Workbook

Thirty-two questions, none of them repeated from the Complete Learning Session's sixteen. Correct-answer letters run strictly A -> B -> C -> D, eight times each. Every question carries four per-option explanations (128 in total) and one examiner trap note (32 in total).

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which phase of British economic impact is correctly matched with its dominant mechanism?

A. c.1757-65 to the late eighteenth century - tribute-taking and trade monopoly B. 1813 to 1833 - railway-borne integration of interior markets C. The 1850s onward - the Company's Indian trade monopoly at its height D. 1793 onward - a uniform all-India land settlement

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: the conquest phase after the acquisition of Bengal revenue was dominated by tribute extraction and monopoly trading.
- **B.** Wrong: railway construction belongs to the 1850s onward, not to the 1813-33 statutory turn.
- **C.** Wrong: the Company's Indian trade monopoly ended in 1813 and its China monopoly in 1833, so it was not at its height in the 1850s.
- **D.** Wrong: no uniform all-India settlement ever existed; Permanent, Ryotwari and Mahalwari were regionally distinct.

Trap logic: Phases are defined by dominant mechanism and overlap in time; do not treat them as sealed eras with hard start dates.

Q2. Which distinction is essential when assessing extraction?

A. Company plunder and continuing drain are interchangeable descriptions of one process B. Company plunder, continuing drain and structural underdevelopment are three distinct ideas, the first feeding the second and both contributing to the third C. Structural underdevelopment preceded both plunder and drain D. Only structural underdevelopment is a legitimate historical category

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: plunder is episodic and conquest-linked, while drain is ongoing and institutional; merging them loses the causal sequence.
- **B.** Correct: the three are separate analytical categories with a stated causal order, and naming all three is what a strong impact answer requires.
- **C.** Wrong: structural underdevelopment is the longer-run outcome, not the starting point.
- **D.** Wrong: plunder and drain are both evidenced categories with identifiable institutional content.

Trap logic: Collapsing the three into one undifferentiated 'exploitation' is the commonest way this answer loses analytical marks.

Q3. Which commodity list correctly represents the pre-colonial export baseline?

A. Machine-made yarn, mill cloth, railway equipment and refined steel B. Coal, mineral oil, cement and chemical dyes C. Cotton textiles, raw silk, indigo, saltpetre, opium, sugar, rice, spices and precious stones D. Tea, jute manufactures, manganese ore and processed leather

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: these are the products of mechanised industry and are precisely what India later imported or produced under colonial industrialisation.

- **B.** Wrong: these are modern extractive and chemical-industry products, not the pre-colonial export basket.
- **C.** Correct: this is the baseline commodity list on which the deindustrialisation argument depends.
- **D.** Wrong: tea and jute manufactures are colonial-era plantation and factory products, not pre-colonial exports.

Trap logic: The baseline must be stated as commodities actually exported; a vague claim of 'prosperity' cannot carry the deindustrialisation argument.

Q4. Why is the pre-colonial baseline deliberately stated narrowly?

A. Because no evidence of pre-colonial trade survives B. Because the syllabus forbids any reference to the pre-colonial period C. Because the pre-colonial economy is owned by a different subject D. Because a narrow export-sector claim is sufficient to make deindustrialisation logically possible, while a wide golden-age claim is both unevidenced and unnecessary

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: substantial trade evidence survives, which is exactly why the commodity list can be stated.
- **B.** Wrong: the baseline is required by the chapter and is taught within it.
- **C.** Wrong: the baseline is used here as the precondition of this chapter's own argument.
- **D.** Correct: a base that existed can be eroded, and that is all the argument requires.

Trap logic: Adding a golden-age claim does not strengthen the argument - it exposes it to an easy and fatal counter-example.

Q5. Which combination correctly describes the Permanent Settlement?

A. Cornwallis, 1793, Bengal-Bihar-Orissa, demand fixed in perpetuity on the zamindari estate B. Munro, 1820, Madras, demand fixed in perpetuity on the ryot's holding C. Holt Mackenzie, 1822, North-Western Provinces, demand fixed in perpetuity on the mahal D. Wellesley, 1798, Awadh, demand fixed in perpetuity on the district

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: architect, year, region and assessment unit all match the Permanent Settlement.
- **B.** Wrong: Munro is associated with Ryotwari in Madras, and Ryotwari was periodically revised, not permanent.
- **C.** Wrong: Holt Mackenzie framed Mahalwari, which used the mahal but was periodically revised.
- **D.** Wrong: this conflates a subsidiary-alliance-era Governor-General with a revenue settlement he did not make.

Trap logic: Permanence is the identifying feature. Any option pairing permanence with Ryotwari or Mahalwari is wrong by definition.

Q6. What was the direct consequence of the Sunset Law for zamindars?

A. Their rent demand on cultivators was statutorily capped B. Failure to pay the fixed revenue by the appointed date exposed the estate itself to sale, producing turnover of proprietors C. They were required to reside on their estates or forfeit their title D. Their assessment was automatically reduced in a year of poor harvest

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: 1793 fixed the state's claim on the zamindar, not the zamindar's rent on the ryot.
- **B.** Correct: default triggered sale of the proprietary right itself, which is the mechanism behind proprietor turnover and absentee landlordism.
- **C.** Wrong: no residence requirement followed from the settlement; absentee tendencies in fact grew.
- **D.** Wrong: the whole design point was that the demand did not vary with the harvest.

Trap logic: Do not import remission-in-bad-years into the Permanent Settlement; the absence of remission is precisely what made it risky.

Q7. Which statement about rights under the Permanent Settlement is correct?

A. Cultivators received the same permanent, heritable security as zamindars in 1793 B. The settlement abolished all intermediaries between the state and the cultivator C. The zamindar's proprietorship was recognised in 1793, while cultivator occupancy security was addressed only later and incompletely D. The settlement conferred no property rights on anyone

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: 1793 secured the zamindar's position, not the tenant's; the two are separate questions.
- **B.** Wrong: the settlement created a recognised intermediary and in practice encouraged further layers of sub-infeudation.
- **C.** Correct: this separation of proprietorship from occupancy is the precision the chapter demands.
- **D.** Wrong: zamindars were recognised as proprietors, which is the settlement's defining grant.

Trap logic: A weak answer treats 'property rights' as a single undifferentiated grant; the examinable point is who received which right, and when.

Q8. With whom is the Ryotwari settlement principally associated?

A. Cornwallis and John Shore B. Holt Mackenzie and R. M. Bird C. Warren Hastings and Philip Francis D. Alexander Read and Thomas Munro

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: Cornwallis is the architect of the Permanent Settlement, a different system entirely.
- **B.** Wrong: Mackenzie and Bird belong to Mahalwari in the North-Western Provinces.
- **C.** Wrong: these belong to the earlier revenue experiments preceding the settled systems.
- **D.** Correct: Read and Munro are the names attached to Ryotwari, applied largely in Madras and Bombay.

Trap logic: Architect-to-system matching is a standard Prelims format; learn the three pairs as fixed units.

Q9. Which feature of Ryotwari most directly exposed the cultivator to indebtedness?

A. A periodically revised cash demand falling due on a fixed calendar, payable by the ryot personally B. A permanent, never-revised demand C. Collective liability shared across the village body D. Payment of revenue in grain rather than cash

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: a fixed-date cash obligation on a variable income forces borrowing in a poor season, leading to mortgage and land alienation.
- **B.** Wrong: permanence of demand is the Permanent Settlement's feature, not Ryotwari's.
- **C.** Wrong: joint liability is Mahalwari's feature; Ryotwari's liability is individual.
- **D.** Wrong: the cash character of the demand is central to the mechanism; payment in grain would have blunted it.

Trap logic: Removing the zamindar removed a layer of extraction but not the rigidity of the demand - Ryotwari is not automatically pro-peasant.

Q10. Which pairing correctly describes the making of the Mahalwari settlement?

A. Thomas Munro framed it and Cornwallis implemented it B. Holt Mackenzie supplied the framework and R. M. Bird carried out the large-scale settlement operations C. Lord Dalhousie framed it and William Bentinck implemented it D. Alexander Read framed it and John Shore implemented it

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: Munro belongs to Ryotwari and Cornwallis to the Permanent Settlement.
- **B.** Correct: framework and implementation are attributed to Mackenzie and Bird respectively in the North-Western Provinces.
- **C.** Wrong: neither is the architect of Mahalwari; this pairs two Governors-General with a system neither designed.
- **D.** Wrong: Read belongs to Ryotwari and Shore to the Permanent Settlement debates.

Trap logic: Distinguish who framed a system from who executed it - the question format frequently tests exactly this split.

Q11. What is the practical consequence of joint liability under Mahalwari?

A. Each co-sharer was liable only for his own share and no more B. The state collected directly from each individual cultivator, bypassing the village C. A defaulting co-sharer's burden fell on the remaining members of the mahal, so one failure raised the effective demand on the rest D. The demand was fixed in perpetuity for the whole village

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the liability was joint and several, which is the whole distinguishing feature.
- **B.** Wrong: direct individual settlement describes Ryotwari, not Mahalwari.
- **C.** Correct: joint liability buffers an individual bad year but transmits default across the village body.
- **D.** Wrong: Mahalwari was periodically revised; permanence belongs to the 1793 settlement.

Trap logic: Joint liability is double-edged - say both what it buffers and what it transmits, rather than presenting it as simple village protection.

Q12. Which conclusion follows from comparing the three settlements on controlled axes?

A. Ryotwari was uniformly pro-peasant across all regions where it operated B. Permanent Settlement was applied throughout British India after 1793 C. The three systems differed only in the name given to the revenue officer D. They differed in architect, region, unit, revision and risk carrier, while converging on a secure cash demand; none covered all India and all changed in practice

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: Ryotwari made the cultivator the state's debtor of record on a fixed calendar, which is not automatically favourable.
- **B.** Wrong: the Permanent Settlement was confined to Bengal, Bihar and Orissa and some later extensions, not to all British India.
- **C.** Wrong: the differences are structural - unit, revision and liability - not nominal.
- **D.** Correct: this states both the variation and the common fiscal core, with the two required qualifications.

Trap logic: A static all-India settlement map is historically wrong; always add that all three were modified by later legislation and revision.

Q13. What was the primary compulsion driving the commercialisation of agriculture?

A. A cash revenue demand falling due on a fixed calendar, which forced cultivators to obtain money before harvest B. A statutory prohibition on growing food crops C. A colonial policy of compulsory crop rotation enforced by the Forest Department D. The disappearance of all local grain markets

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: the cash calendar is the origin of the chain that runs through advances and credit to cash-crop commitment.
- **B.** Wrong: no such prohibition existed; food cultivation continued alongside cash crops.
- **C.** Wrong: the Forest Department regulated forest access, not crop rotation on settled land.
- **D.** Wrong: local grain markets persisted; the issue was the cultivator's ability to bid in them.

Trap logic: Begin the commercialisation answer at the revenue calendar, not at 'British greed' - the mechanism is what earns marks.

Q14. How did the advance system tie cultivators to particular crops?

A. By offering guaranteed minimum prices set by the colonial government B. By paying money before the season against a commitment to deliver a specified crop, so the cropping decision was made before the harvest and before the price were known C. By supplying free irrigation to cash-crop growers only D. By exempting cash-crop cultivators from land revenue

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: no guaranteed minimum price regime existed; the cultivator carried the price risk.
- **B.** Correct: pre-season money against a tied delivery obligation is what removed the cultivator's freedom to respond to later price signals.
- **C.** Wrong: irrigation provision was not structured as a free benefit tied to cash cropping.
- **D.** Wrong: revenue liability continued regardless of the crop grown.

Trap logic: The advance is not simply credit - it is credit that pre-commits the crop, which is why a crop boycott was the effective counter-weapon.

Q15. What is the concrete, evidenced outcome of the commercialisation-and-credit chain?

A. A general rise in cultivator incomes across all regions B. A statutory transfer of land to cultivating tenants C. Indebtedness leading to mortgage and land alienation, with the former holder often continuing as tenant or wage labourer D. The abolition of moneylending in the countryside

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: gains were real in some regions and crops but were not general; the claim concerns the distribution of risk.
- **B.** Wrong: tenancy legislation came later, partially, and did not follow automatically from commercialisation.
- **C.** Correct: this is the concrete mechanism that converts an abstract risk claim into evidenced agrarian change.
- **D.** Wrong: moneylending expanded rather than disappeared, and became a target of protest in the Deccan.

Trap logic: Name the endpoint - mortgage and land alienation - rather than stopping at the word 'exploitation'.

Q16. Under which arrangements were cultivators bound to indigo production before 1859-60?

A. Permanent Settlement and Sunset Law obligations B. Mahalwari joint-liability bonds C. Famine Code labour requirements D. The nij and ryoti cultivation arrangements operated by European planters through advances

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: these are land-revenue instruments between the state and the zamindar, not planter-cultivator contracts.
- **B.** Wrong: joint liability concerned revenue payment in the mahal, not indigo cultivation in Bengal.
- **C.** Wrong: the Famine Code framework followed the 1880 Strachey Commission and concerns relief, not cropping.
- **D.** Correct: nij and ryoti describe the planter's direct and tenant-based cultivation arrangements, both resting on advances.

Trap logic: Knowing the two terms lets you explain why refusal to sow - rather than litigation - was the effective weapon against planters.

Q17. Against whom was the Pabna agrarian league movement from 1873 directed?

A. Zamindars attempting rent enhancement beyond legally recognised limits B. European indigo planters enforcing advance contracts C. Deccan moneylenders holding written debt bonds D. Forest Department officials enforcing reserved-forest boundaries

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: Pabna's adversary was the zamindar, and the grievance was unlawful rent enhancement.
- **B.** Wrong: planters were the target of the Indigo disturbances of 1859-60 in a different relationship.
- **C.** Wrong: moneylenders were the target of the Deccan riots of 1875.
- **D.** Wrong: forest grievances form a separate strand of colonial economic conflict.

Trap logic: Match target to grievance first; only then does the choice of repertoire - leagues and litigation - become explicable.

Q18. Which repertoire characterised the Deccan riots of 1875?

A. Collective refusal to sow a commercial crop B. Seizure and destruction of the written bonds and mortgage documents held by moneylenders C. Formation of leagues and pooled litigation against rent enhancement D. Petitioning the Governor-General for tariff protection

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: crop refusal was the Indigo repertoire, effective against advance-based cultivation contracts.
- **B.** Correct: because the creditor's power rested on documents, destroying the documents attacked the power directly.
- **C.** Wrong: leagues and litigation characterise Pabna, where a legal limit on rent could be invoked.
- **D.** Wrong: tariff petitioning belongs to the nationalist economic critique, not to these agrarian episodes.

Trap logic: Each repertoire is rational for its adversary - never present the three episodes as one undifferentiated 'agrarian unrest'.

Q19. Which definition of deindustrialisation is examination-safe?

A. The complete disappearance of Indian manufacturing B. India's failure to undergo an industrial revolution of its own C. A relative decline in the output, employment or bargaining position of Indian handicrafts, uneven across regions, crafts and periods D. The replacement of all Indian artisans by factory workers in Indian mills

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: coarse cloth and many village crafts persisted; total extinction is contradicted by the evidence.
- **B.** Wrong: that is a different proposition and would not require a pre-existing base at all.
- **C.** Correct: relative decline with explicit variation is the formulation the evidence supports.
- **D.** Wrong: the modern mill sector did not absorb displaced artisans; the two occupied different products, places and labour markets.

Trap logic: Deindustrialisation and failure-to-industrialise are different claims requiring different evidence; do not use them interchangeably.

Q20. Which set names the principal strands of the deindustrialisation causal web?

A. Famine, plague, migration and war B. Permanent Settlement, Ryotwari, Mahalwari and the Guarantee System C. Council Bills, home charges, pensions and stores purchases D. Mechanised British production, tariff and market asymmetry, loss of court and elite patronage, and railway penetration of interior markets

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: these are demographic and conjunctural events, not the mechanisms of craft decline.
- **B.** Wrong: these are revenue and infrastructure-financing instruments belonging to other subtopics.
- **C.** Wrong: these are channels of the drain, a transfer mechanism distinct from craft decline.
- **D.** Correct: these four strands supply capacity, access, demand collapse and distribution respectively.

Trap logic: Drain and deindustrialisation are different mechanisms - an answer that fuses them loses the distinction examiners are testing.

Q21. What role did the railways play in the deindustrialisation argument?

A. They carried machine-made imports into interior markets and carried raw materials outward, extending the reach of a shock that had previously been confined to coastal trade B. They were built specifically to protect Indian handicraft producers from imports C. They had no measurable effect on the internal circulation of goods D. They were financed entirely by Indian capital and served Indian manufacturing priorities

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: the railway is the distribution strand of the causal web, not the origin of the shock.
- **B.** Wrong: no protective purpose existed; commercial policy ran the other way.
- **C.** Wrong: market integration is one of the few effects on which all schools agree.
- **D.** Wrong: the Guarantee System drew private British capital with an assured return met from Indian revenues if necessary.

Trap logic: Railways are an amplifier, not a cause - a single-cause railway explanation of craft decline misstates the mechanism.

Q22. Which verdict correctly answers a 'how far' question on the Industrial Revolution and Indian handicrafts?

A. The Industrial Revolution bears no responsibility at all B. It was substantially responsible as a necessary condition, but became decisive only through colonial policy instruments, and with variation by region, craft and period C. It was wholly and solely responsible, with colonial policy irrelevant D. The question cannot be answered because the evidence is entirely absent

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: denying the premise outright ignores the genuine cost advantage of mechanised production.
- **B.** Correct: conceding necessity and then weighing colonial policy through the counterfactual of tariff autonomy is the graded verdict the directive requires.
- **C.** Wrong: this abandons the independent weight of tariff asymmetry, policy control, court decline and railway access.
- **D.** Wrong: the evidence is contested in magnitude but substantial in kind.

Trap logic: 'How far' punishes binary answers; the marks lie in the distribution of responsibility, not in the side chosen.

Q23. Which statement correctly separates artisan displacement from de-urbanisation?

A. They are two names for the same measured phenomenon B. Displacement concerns towns while de-urbanisation concerns crafts C. Displacement is a claim about occupational structure; de-urbanisation is a claim about settlement pattern, and the two can move in opposite directions in different places D. Neither claim can be supported by any evidence whatsoever

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: they operate at different levels of analysis and need different evidence.
- **B.** Wrong: this reverses the two definitions.
- **C.** Correct: craft and court towns could contract while port and railway towns grew, which only the separated claims can express.
- **D.** Wrong: the direction of change is evidenced even though the quantitative series are thin.

Trap logic: Argue both claims qualitatively and state the evidence limits; do not invent a workforce share or a town population.

Q24. Which item is NOT a channel of the drain of wealth under a precise drain definition?

A. Home charges and India Office costs met from Indian revenues B. Interest and profit on British capital, including the assured returns of the railway Guarantee System C. Stores purchased in Britain on Indian account D. Land revenue collected from Indian cultivators and spent within India on district administration

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong as the answer: this is a core drain channel, being an obligation discharged in Britain.
- **B.** Wrong as the answer: these are claims settled abroad and belong to the channel list.
- **C.** Wrong as the answer: procurement abroad on Indian account is a recognised channel.
- **D.** Correct: revenue raised and spent inside India is domestic fiscal transfer, not an external unilateral transfer; treating it as drain destroys the concept's precision.

Trap logic: The drain is defined by external settlement without equivalent return; internal taxation, however heavy, is a separate criticism.

Q25. What is the correct discipline when writing about the magnitude of the drain?

A. Name the channels and explain the mechanism, but assert no total, annual figure or percentage, because the aggregate is disputed and depends on what counts as a legitimate administrative cost B. State a single agreed annual figure accepted by all historians C. Express the drain as a fixed percentage of national income for every year of colonial rule D. Avoid the concept altogether because it cannot be quantified

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: the channel argument is evidentially secure while the aggregate is not, so the answer claims exactly what it can defend.
- **B.** Wrong: no such agreed figure exists; nationalist estimates and revisionist critiques diverge sharply.
- **C.** Wrong: national-income series for the colonial period are themselves reconstructions with wide error margins.
- **D.** Wrong: unquantifiability of the total does not invalidate the identification of the channels.

Trap logic: Conceding the measurement problem strengthens the answer; an invented figure is the fastest way to lose credibility on this chapter.

Q26. Who wrote 'Poverty and Un-British Rule in India'?

A. R. C. Dutt B. Dadabhai Naoroji C. M. G. Ranade D. Daniel Thorner

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: Dutt's work is 'The Economic History of India'.
- **B.** Correct: Naoroji's work centres the drain as the mechanism of Indian poverty.
- **C.** Wrong: Ranade argued for Indian industrial development and a constructive state role.
- **D.** Wrong: Thorner is a twentieth-century revisionist scholar, not a nationalist economic writer.

Trap logic: Swapping Naoroji's and Dutt's books is a standard distractor - fix the author-to-title pairing before the exam.

Q27. Which emphasis is correctly attributed to R. C. Dutt?

A. The case for protective tariffs to build modern Indian industry B. A statistical critique of the deindustrialisation thesis C. The reconstruction of land-revenue and agrarian pressure from official records in 'The Economic History of India' D. The argument that Indian poverty was caused by climate and custom

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the industrial-development emphasis belongs to Ranade.
- **B.** Wrong: the statistical critique is the revisionist position of Morris D. Morris and Daniel Thorner.
- **C.** Correct: Dutt's distinctive contribution is the record-based reconstruction of agrarian and revenue pressure.
- **D.** Wrong: the nationalist critique exists precisely to displace climate-and-custom explanations.

Trap logic: The three nationalist writers made three distinguishable arguments; do not reduce them to a single undifferentiated complaint.

Q28. Which position is correctly attributed to M. G. Ranade?

A. That the drain alone explains Indian poverty and no other mechanism is needed B. That Indian poverty is best explained by population growth C. That colonial economic policy had no measurable effect on India D. That Indian poverty was a problem of production structure requiring industrial development and a constructive state role

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the drain-centred emphasis belongs to Naoroji.
- **B.** Wrong: no nationalist economic writer rested the case on population growth.
- **C.** Wrong: that is closer to an extreme apologist position that none of the three held.
- **D.** Correct: Ranade shifts the argument from transfer to production structure, which complements rather than replaces the drain argument.

Trap logic: Adding Ranade's production-structure argument to a drain answer shows range; using it as a substitute for the drain misattributes his position.

Q29. What did the Council Bill mechanism achieve?

A. Sterling raised in London against rupee funds in India, so that India's recorded export surplus could service home charges and other external obligations instead of returning as goods or investment B. A fixed exchange rate guaranteed by the Reserve Bank from 1793 C. Direct British grants to Indian provincial governments D. Convertibility of Indian currency into gold for ordinary cultivators

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: this is the instrument that links the trade account to the drain's channels.
- **B.** Wrong: the Reserve Bank did not exist in 1793, and no such guarantee is claimed here.
- **C.** Wrong: the flow ran the other way, as obligations settled abroad from Indian resources.
- **D.** Wrong: no such convertibility arrangement for cultivators existed.

Trap logic: Do not attach an adopted rupee-sterling ratio to this answer; 1s 4d belongs only to Gandhi's 1930 eleven-point demand and the Hilton-Young adopted rate is treated here as unverified.

Q30. What was the essential feature of the railway Guarantee System?

A. Indian princely states underwrote all railway construction costs B. Private British capital received an assured minimum return, with any shortfall met from Indian revenues, so commercial risk was borne in India while the return was secured in Britain C. Railways were built and owned entirely by the Government of India from the outset D. Railway companies bore the whole commercial risk of construction and operation

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: princely-state finance was not the basis of the main network's construction.
- **B.** Correct: the risk-return asymmetry is why railway finance appears in the drain discussion as well as in the infrastructure discussion.
- **C.** Wrong: state construction and ownership came later and only partially.
- **D.** Wrong: the guarantee existed precisely to remove that risk from the companies.

Trap logic: Railways belong to two answers at once - infrastructure and drain - and naming the Guarantee System is what connects them.

Q31. Which sequence of colonial forest measures is correct?

A. Indian Forest Act 1878, then Government Forests Act 1865, then Forest Department 1864 B. Government Forests Act 1865, then Indian Forest Act 1878, then Forest Department 1864 C. Forest Department 1864, then Government Forests Act 1865, then Indian Forest Act 1878, with reserved, protected and unclassified categories D. Forest Department 1878, then Indian Forest Act 1865, then Government Forests Act 1864

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: this reverses the sequence entirely.
- **B.** Wrong: the Department preceded both statutes.
- **C.** Correct: department first, then the 1865 Act, then the 1878 Act with its threefold classification of forests.
- **D.** Wrong: the dates are attached to the wrong instruments.

Trap logic: Forest law belongs to this chapter as infrastructure of extraction; the curtailment of customary use is the link to tribal resistance.

Q32. Which feature-set best identifies the restrictive relief doctrine that could limit famine response even after administrative codification?

A. Automatic revenue remission, universal grain entitlement and unconditional cash support B. Reliance only on irrigation engineering, with no rules governing relief eligibility C. Complete rejection of market exchange and compulsory state seizure of all private grain D. Work tests, cost ceilings, delayed official declaration and reluctance to interfere in grain trade

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: colonial relief did not guarantee universal, unconditional support or automatic remission.
- **B.** Wrong: irrigation policy alone does not describe the administrative doctrine governing famine relief.
- **C.** Wrong: the doctrine was generally reluctant to interfere with markets rather than committed to universal grain seizure.
- **D.** Correct: work tests, expenditure restraint, delayed declaration and faith in market allocation could restrict access to relief even after famine administration was codified.

Trap logic: A written famine code is an administrative instrument, not proof that relief was timely, accessible or adequate in practice.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS WITH SOLUTIONS

Only verified Mains questions are solved below. Objective demands without a secure final key are retained without an answer letter.

PYQ 01 - UPSC 2022, GS-I Mains, Q3 (10 marks, 150 words)

Question: "Why was there a sudden spurt in famines in colonial India since the mid-eighteenth century? Give reasons." **10 marks · 150 words.**

Solved model answer

Directive control. "Give reasons" requires named causal mechanisms in sequence, not a general narrative of colonial hardship.

A climatic harvest shock - drought or monsoon failure - was usually the immediate trigger, but colonial-era conditions converted scarcity into mass mortality through four identifiable amplifiers.

First, revenue rigidity: a cash demand falling due on a fixed calendar under the Permanent Settlement and Ryotwari could not be deferred in a bad year, forcing distress sales of grain reserves at exactly the wrong moment.

Second, commercialisation exposure: advances and credit had tied cultivation to cash crops for distant markets, thinning the household and village food buffers that had previously absorbed a single failed season.

Third, price-directed transport: expanding rail capacity moved grain along price signals rather than toward deficit areas, so food could leave a famine district that could no longer bid for it.

Fourth, relief doctrine and administrative delay: restrictive relief principles, work tests and late official declaration compounded distress before the Strachey Commission of 1880 codified relief - and severe famine recurred in 1896-1900 even after that codification.

Qualification. This does not claim colonial rule invented famine in India, nor that climate was irrelevant. It claims that specific colonial mechanisms removed the buffers that might otherwise have absorbed a recurring shock.

Why this earns marks. Naming at least three of the four amplifiers, and keeping the trigger analytically separate from them, is what converts a descriptive answer into a causal one. No mortality figure is asserted.

PYQ 02 - UPSC 2024, GS-I Mains, Q13 (15 marks, 250 words)

Question: "How far was the Industrial Revolution in England responsible for the decline of handicrafts and cottage industries in India?" **Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words.**

Solved model answer

Directive control. "Discuss" on a causal proposition requires the premise to be engaged on both sides and a graded verdict returned, not a one-sided narration.

The Industrial Revolution was a necessary condition for the decline of Indian handicrafts: mechanised spinning and weaving in England produced yarn and cloth at unit costs no hand process could match, and the resulting capacity had to find markets.

It was not, however, sufficient on its own. The shock reached Indian producers through four colonial transmission mechanisms. Tariff and market asymmetry gave British manufactures access to Indian markets on terms Indian goods did not enjoy in Britain. Political control of commercial policy meant India could not adjust duties in response. The decline of Indian courts removed the elite patronage that had sustained the finest crafts. Railway penetration from the 1850s carried machine-made imports into interior markets and carried raw materials outward.

The counterfactual clarifies the weighting: an economy holding tariff autonomy could have slowed, buffered or redirected the same technological shock, as other nineteenth-century economies did. The independent weight of colonial policy therefore stands alongside the technological cause rather than behind it.

Qualification. The outcome varied by region, craft and period. Coarse cloth, village crafts and several specialised trades persisted, so no claim of total extinction survives the evidence, and the aggregate magnitude of craft decline remains disputed - Morris D. Morris and Daniel Thorner challenge its scale and measurability.

Verdict. The Industrial Revolution was substantially responsible, but it became decisive only through colonial policy instruments.

UNSOLVED OBJECTIVE DEMAND-CONTROLS - no secure final key used

These objective demands are retained without an answer letter because a secure final key is unavailable or the item was dropped.

Year	Paper	Q	Demand	Status
2018	Prelims GS-I	52	Economic results of British rule in nineteenth-century India	No answer letter supplied
2018	Prelims GS-I	68	East India Company export commodities from Bengal, mid-century	No answer letter supplied
2020	Prelims GS-I	23	Impact of the Industrial Revolution on India in the nineteenth century	No answer letter supplied
2020	Prelims GS-I	33	Decline of indigo cultivation in early twentieth-century India	No answer letter supplied
2024	Prelims GS-I	57	Revenue collection under Cornwallis	**Officially dropped**; retained only as a demand-control
2026	Prelims GS-I	2	Hilton-Young Commission rupee-sterling exchange rate	The 2026 Set-A key is **provisional**; no answer letter is supplied

Adjacent cross-links. 2018 Prelims Q51 (colonial measures after the Santhal Uprising subsided) and 2018 GS-I Q13 (indentured labour) are bounded bridges rather than direct economic questions, and are not solved here.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Six original questions - two at 10 marks (150 words), two at 15 marks (250 words) and two at 20 marks (250 words). None of these is a PYQ; the verified PYQs are solved separately in the preceding PYQ section. Word limits apply to the answer body; the directive, qualification and marks notes are examiner scaffolding around it.

Mains 10M-1 - Examine the institutional mechanism through which the Permanent Settlement of 1793 combined absolute revenue certainty for the state with genuine dispossession risk for the zamindar.

Original practice question - 10 marks | 150 words | GS-I.

Directive control. "Examine" requires the precise mechanism to be named and tested, not the settlement merely described.

Model answer

Cornwallis's settlement of 1793 fixed the state's land-revenue demand in perpetuity across Bengal, Bihar and Orissa, recognising zamindars as proprietors in exchange for that permanently fixed obligation. The state's security was absolute: the demand could never be revised upward however much a zamindar's income improved.

The corresponding risk operated through one rule. Under the Sunset Law, failure to pay the fixed demand by the appointed date exposed the zamindari estate itself to sale, transferring the proprietary right to a purchaser. A permanent demand meeting a variable harvest therefore produced turnover of proprietors, absentee tendencies and layered rent-collecting intermediaries.

Cultivator rights were a separate and less protected question: 1793 fixed the state's claim on the zamindar, not the zamindar's rent on the ryot, and occupancy security was addressed only later and incompletely.

Qualification. It was not uniformly ruinous: zamindars who met the demand gained lasting security, so the outcome was differentiation.

Why this earns marks. Naming the Sunset Law explicitly, and separating zamindar proprietorship from cultivator occupancy, is the precision this question rewards.

Mains 10M-2 - Distinguish the target and the method of collective action in the Indigo disturbances of 1859-60 from those of the Pabna agrarian league movement from 1873.

Original practice question - 10 marks | 150 words | GS-I.

Directive control. "Distinguish" requires a paired comparison on controlled variables, not two separate descriptions.

Model answer

The two episodes differ on both variables that matter.

Target. The Indigo disturbances of 1859-60 in Bengal confronted European indigo planters directly. The Pabna movement from 1873 in eastern Bengal confronted Bengali zamindars attempting rent enhancement beyond legally recognised limits.

Method. Against planters, the effective weapon was a collective refusal to sow indigo, because the planters' power rested on advance-based nij and ryoti cultivation obligations that a crop boycott nullified at source. Against zamindars, the effective weapons were organisational and legal - agrarian leagues, pooled funds, rent resistance and litigation - because the grievance was an unlawful rent demand that courts could be made to test.

Each repertoire is therefore the rational form of action against that specific economic relationship.

Qualification. Both are used here strictly as economic-response case studies; their fuller political and organisational history belongs to the wider history of peasant and worker movements.

Why this earns marks. Stating target and repertoire as paired variables, and explaining why each repertoire fitted its adversary, converts description into comparison.

Mains 15M-1 - Analyse the drain of wealth as a transfer mechanism rather than as a quantified total, and assess what this framing gains and what it concedes.

Original practice question - 15 marks | 250 words | GS-I.

Directive control. "Analyse" requires the concept to be broken into its components and the analytical consequences of that framing to be stated.

Model answer

The drain of wealth is a transfer concept, not a trade concept. It names a unilateral movement of resources from India to Britain for which India received no equivalent economic return, and it is strongest when argued through its channels.

Those channels are institutionally identifiable. Home charges and India Office costs were met from Indian revenues. Salaries, pensions and private remittances carried official income out of India. Interest and profit on British capital, including the assured returns of the railway Guarantee System, were claims settled abroad. Stores were purchased in Britain on Indian account, and imperial military and external expenditure was charged to Indian revenues.

The Council Bill mechanism connects these claims to the trade account. Bills sold in London against rupee funds in India allowed India's recorded surplus of exports over visible imports to service sterling obligations rather than return as goods or investment. A surplus, on this reading, is not evidence of national gain.

What the framing gains is evidential security: each channel can be named and dated, and the argument survives the statistical objection. What it concedes is magnitude. Revisionist scholarship disputes how much of this was a genuine transfer rather than a payment for administration and infrastructure actually delivered, and the surviving series cannot settle the question.

Qualification. The concession is deliberate. No total, annual figure or percentage of national income is asserted here, because the aggregate remains disputed and depends on what is counted as a legitimate administrative cost.

Why this earns marks. Naming at least four channels, adding the Council Bill link, and openly conceding the measurement problem is what distinguishes this from a slogan-level drain answer.

Mains 15M-2 - Compare the Permanent, Ryotwari and Mahalwari settlements on assessment unit, revision pattern and risk carrier, and assess whether any of them can properly be called pro-peasant.

Original practice question - 15 marks | 250 words | GS-I.

Directive control. "Compare and assess" requires controlled comparison followed by an explicit verdict on the stated characterisation.

Model answer

The three settlements differ on three controlled axes.

Assessment unit. The Permanent Settlement assessed the zamindari estate; Ryotwari assessed the individual ryot's holding; Mahalwari assessed the mahal, the village or estate taken as a whole.

Revision. The Permanent Settlement fixed the demand in perpetuity under Cornwallis in 1793 for Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. Ryotwari, associated with Alexander Read and Thomas Munro in Madras and Bombay, revised the assessment periodically by survey. Mahalwari, framed by Holt Mackenzie and implemented at scale by R. M. Bird in the North-Western Provinces, was likewise periodically revised.

Risk carrier. Under the Permanent Settlement the zamindar carried residual risk, and passed it downward as rent. Under Ryotwari the cultivator carried it directly, as the state's debtor of record. Under Mahalwari the village body carried it jointly, so one co-sharer's default raised the burden on the rest.

On the verdict: none was pro-peasant. Ryotwari removed an intermediary but substituted a direct, periodically revisable cash demand on a fixed calendar, which in a poor season produced borrowing, mortgage and land alienation. Mahalwari's joint liability buffered an individual bad year but transmitted default across the village.

Qualification. No settlement covered the whole subcontinent and all three were modified by later legislation and revision, so a static all-India map of settlements misstates the position.

Why this earns marks. Answering on fixed axes in a fixed order, then returning an explicit verdict on the 'pro-peasant' characterisation, satisfies both halves of the directive.

Mains 20M-1 - Critically examine the proposition that British rule produced modernisation of circulation in India without autonomous development.

Original practice question - 20 marks | 250 words | GS-I.

Directive control. "Critically examine" requires the proposition to be tested against contrary evidence before a qualified verdict is returned.

Model answer

The proposition holds, but only after the contrary evidence is conceded in full.

What supports it. Revenue and property were redesigned through the Permanent, Ryotwari and Mahalwari settlements to secure a cash demand on a fixed calendar. Commercialisation pushed price and harvest risk downward through advances and credit. Handicrafts declined under mechanised British production, tariff asymmetry, lost court patronage and railway penetration. Drain channels - home charges, remittances, guaranteed returns, stores and imperial expenditure - settled claims abroad. Railways were financed through the Guarantee System, which assured British capital a return while Indian revenues met the shortfall.

What resists it. Modernisation was real. Railways, ports, telegraph, canal irrigation and codified law were built. Plantations, jute, cotton mills, coal and later iron and steel constituted a genuine modern sector. Market integration and mobility were real, and later served the nationalist movement itself.

The reconciliation lies in direction and control. Circulation was modernised - goods, information and people moved faster - while tariff policy, currency policy, the composition of public expenditure and the terms of external settlement were determined outside Indian hands. Craft decline and modern-sector growth coexisted because they occupied different products, places and labour markets, so the new sector never absorbed the displaced.

Qualification. Revisionist scholarship, including Morris D. Morris and Daniel Thorner, disputes the scale and measurability of decline, and regional outcomes varied sharply; the proposition therefore rests on the distribution of benefit and the location of control, not on any unquantified claim of total loss.

Why this earns marks. Conceding the modernisation case in detail before returning the located-control verdict is what 'critically examine' rewards; a one-sided answer forfeits the critical component.

Mains 20M-2 - Evaluate the view that nineteenth-century Indian famines were failures of entitlement and governance rather than of food availability.

Original practice question - 20 marks | 250 words | GS-I.

Directive control. "Evaluate" requires the stated view to be weighed against its alternative and a reasoned judgement delivered.

Model answer

The view is largely sustainable, provided the climatic trigger is conceded rather than denied.

The case for it. Drought or monsoon failure supplied the shock, but four mechanisms converted scarcity into mass mortality. Revenue rigidity meant a cash demand fell due on a fixed calendar irrespective of the harvest, forcing distress sales of reserves. Commercialisation had replaced local food buffers with cash crops and credit obligations. Transport followed price rather than need, so grain could move out of a district that could no longer bid for it. Relief doctrine imposed work tests, cost ceilings and late declaration. Together these destroy the ability to command food even where food exists in the wider market, which is precisely what entitlement failure means.

The governance case is strengthened by chronology. The 1876-78 famine produced the Strachey Commission of 1880 and a codified relief framework - yet severe famine recurred in 1896-1900. Recurrence after codification points to the doctrinal limits of relief rather than to the absence of policy.

The case against it. Climate cannot be written out: the shocks were real, recurrent and independent of policy. Nor is colonial rule shown to have invented Indian famine, which predates it.

Judgement: availability failure triggered these famines; entitlement and governance failure determined their scale.

Qualification. No mortality figure is asserted for any famine in this sequence, because contemporary estimates vary widely and are disputed; the 1770 and 1943 famines are used only as bounded bridges.

Why this earns marks. Conceding the climatic trigger, then separating trigger from amplifier and using the post-1880 recurrence as the governance test, is what converts a moral claim into an evaluated one.